

So an early recidivism study seemed to indicate that models beat experts, and when deployed in the real world computerized assessments have lowered recidivism. Why do the models beat the experts in predicting recidivism?

The judgments of human parole boards can be affected by human emotion and perception, and can be based on intuition or subjective criteria, with humans focusing on the wrong factors. For instance, human parole boards rely on considerations such as an interview with the offender and whether an offender shows remorse as predictors of future recidivism. But are these the right factors to be emphasizing? Or do parole boards assume these “soft” elements matter, without examining the evidence? Risk assessment models, which are based on research by criminologists, suggest that more subtle, alternative factors, such as age of first arrest, and whether an offender believes his conviction is unfair may be far better indicators of the likelihood of recidivism. Although these signals are statistically strong predictors, they sometimes directly conflict with human intuition.

A Study of All the Studies

Thus far, we've presented a formal study relating to how models beat experts in the domain of recidivism, and how computerized assessments seem to be making a difference in the real world, and described some of the behavioral reasons why this appears to be the case.

In order to make a more convincing case that models beat experts, we require more analysis. Professors William Grove, David Zald, Boyd Lebow, Beth Snitz, and Chad Nelson have performed a meta-analysis—or a study of studies—on 136 published studies that analyze the accuracy of “actuarial” (i.e., computers/models) versus “clinical” (i.e., human experts) judgment.⁵

The studies examined by Grove et al. include forecast accuracy estimates that cut across a huge variety of professions. The studies included examples from the following fields:

- College academic performance
- Magazine advertising sales